whose chariot and army are irresistible, one whose empire is protected by the chief of the empire, descended from the family of the royal sage Vasu, the great conqueror, the king, the illustrious Kharavela’.

There were two good reasons why Kharavela chose Udayagiri as this site for his proclamation. The first was that the Jain teacher Mahavira was said to have preached his doctrines on the hill, making it an especially propitious site for Raja Kharavela to place on record his devotion to Jainism. The second was that the rock face he chose for his inscription looked directly out across the plain to Ashoka’s inscription on Dhauli hill. It was a homage to his great predecessor, whom he himself had set out to emulate, perhaps even overshadow.

Following Ashoka’s death in about 232 BCE his empire had fragmented in the classic pattern as local governors staked their own claims as rulers. There is some evidence of a Brahminical backlash, with the last of the Mauryas ruling in Magadha being assassinated in about 185 BCE by the Brahmin commander of his army, Pushyamitra Shunga. A bout of anti-Buddhist violence and iconoclasm by Pushyamitra then seems to have taken place, followed by a friendlier attitude towards Buddhism under the aegis of the Shungas that allowed a number of damaged Buddhist stupas to be restored and enlarged.

Largely thanks to Ashoka’s promotion of sculpture, Buddhist monastic communities now began to replace the wooden railings of their stupas with carved stone balustrades, enclosures and gateways. Panels were carved to illustrate in bas-relief some of the key elements of Buddhist worship along with episodes from the Buddhist Jatakas, moral tales built around the past lives of the Buddha. Initially, both the Jains and the Buddhists were reluctant to show their respective teachers in anything other than aniconic form, representing them instead by such symbols as a pair of footprints, an empty throne, a royal